



Leaning over an exercise ball This can help you feel more at ease and comfortable during labor.

Q What can I expect to happen during labor? How long is it likely to last?

As your body enters into labor and prepares to give birth to your baby, it will go through a sequence of events and stages. While no two labors are the same, this progress of labor does follow a pattern that helps the doctor and nurses monitor you, and encourages you that your baby is on his way.

ENGAGEMENT

Toward the end of pregnancy, your baby's head drops down into the lowest part of the pelvis, or engages (see p.202), to prepare for labor and delivery. Engagement tends to happen earlier in first pregnancies, when uterine muscles that have never been stretched before can exert greater pressure to push the baby down into the pelvis.

Time it takes This sign of approaching labor can happen any time, from several weeks before labor in first pregnancies to just as labor starts in subsequent pregnancies.

Action Your doctor will palpate your abdomen at your prenatal appointments to find out whether your baby's head is engaged.

1ST STAGE—ACTIVE LABOR AND TRANSITION

The second part of the first stage is known as "active labor." You will know it by frequent, strong contractions that are impossible to ignore. The cervix opens more quickly and at 7–9 cm dilation, the active phase moves into transition, when contractions become more intense and you feel the urge to push. The first stage ends once the cervix is fully dilated, at 10 cm.

Time it takes In an average first labor, the cervix dilates about 1 cm an hour. Active labor can progress much quicker in subsequent labors.

Action Call your doctor when you reach active labor. You will probably be advised to time the contractions and rest at home until the contractions are closer together, about every five minutes and lasting 60 seconds.

3RD STAGE

The third stage marks the delivery of the placenta and membranes after your baby is born. In other countries this final stage may be "actively" managed, when an injection of oxytocin speeds up delivery of the placenta. This is uncommon in the US but if the idea appeals to you, ask your doctor if she gives patients oxytocin injections.

Time it takes A natural third stage takes 20–30 minutes, and this time guide is the same for first and subsequent deliveries.

Action You may need to push a little more to deliver the placenta.

Understanding **how labor works** helps you gauge when to stay at home and when to **call the doctor**.

1ST STAGE—LATENT LABOR

The first stage of labor opens the cervix. Early labor, known as the "latent" phase, is marked by relatively mild, irregular contractions that start to thin and draw up the cervix, a process known as effacement. Then the cervix begins to dilate and will reach around 3–4 cm dilation. The pain is strong but bearable, with periodlike cramping.

Time it takes This longest phase can account for as much as two-thirds of the total time of labor. It can last from several hours to a few days in a first labor; it is often much shorter in subsequent labors.

Action You'll usually be encouraged to stay at home during the latent phase. Try to get comfortable, but keep the contractions going.

2ND STAGE

The second stage of labor begins when the cervix is fully dilated and ends with the birth of your baby. This stage is marked by a strong urge to bear down as contractions push your baby against the pelvic floor. Your doctor will support and guide you, encouraging you to push with your contractions.

Time it takes The active, pushing part of delivering your baby takes roughly 1–2 hours for a first labor, with the total second stage taking up to 3 hours. The second stage in subsequent labors often takes 2 hours or less, with 30 minutes to 1 hour needed for pushing.

Action The end is nearly in sight. Draw encouragement from your birth partner and let your doctor guide you.

